

Evacuation

The final act of US involvement in Vietnam badly damaged the country's global image. America was left humiliated in defeat, as frantic helicopter evacuations left desperate Vietnamese civilians behind.

◀◀ BEFORE

The Paris Peace Accords of January 1973 provided for the exit of US military personnel from South Vietnam, but thousands of US civilians remained in Saigon.

LAST STAND

The communist **Spring Offensive** in March 1975 led to the widespread collapse of South Vietnamese forces. President Thieu tried to organize a defense of Saigon and the Mekong Delta, throwing his last forces into the battle for **Xuan Loc**.

SURRENDER

After Xuan Loc fell, President Thieu resigned. His departure raised hopes for a negotiated end to the war, but NVA commander General Van Tien Dung **attacked and occupied Saigon**. South Vietnam could only surrender.

The sudden collapse of South Vietnamese forces in spring 1975 left the United States with a dilemma. The Ford administration was looking to Congress for aid to South Vietnam that might support the defense of Saigon and pave the way for a negotiated end to the war, avoiding a humiliating total defeat for America's ally. On the other hand, the rapid communist advance posed a clear threat to Americans and other foreigners in Saigon, and to Vietnamese military personnel and civilians who had worked for the Americans or been prominent in government or the ARVN.

Postponing the inevitable

Detailed plans were worked out for a mass evacuation, but implementation was obstructed by concerns that a rapid pullout might fatally undermine the chances of continued South Vietnamese resistance. Graham Martin, the US Ambassador in Saigon, was especially resistant to authorizing a general evacuation, producing elaborate arguments for postponing action. Nonetheless, by early April, US fixed-wing military transport aircraft were making regular flights out of Saigon's Tan Son Nhut airport to evacuate nonessential American personnel and certain categories of "at risk" Vietnamese.